

doc-scripture-sufficiency

Open / Uncertain · Bibliology › Sufficiency · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · Brethren distinctive · confidence: medium

Statement under examination

Scripture is sufficient for faith, doctrine, and practice; no further revelation is needed for salvation or godliness.

Rationale

2 Tim 3:16-17 names every graphē (G1124) as theopneustos (G2315) and ōphelimos (G5624) for didaskalia, elegmos, epanorthōsis, and paideia in dikaiosynē, so that the anthrōpos tou theou may be artios (G739, hapax) and exērtismenos (G1822, perfect passive of exartizō) for every good work. 2 Pet 1:3 reinforces with theia dynamis having dōreomai (G1433, perfect middle) panta (G3956) ta pros zōēn kai eusebeian. Deut 4:2 (lo tosifu, H3254 Hiphil; lo tigre'u, H1639) and Rev 22:18-19 (epitithēmi G2007 / aphaireō G851) frame canonical closure on what is written. The soft form (Scripture is sufficient as the bounded norma normans for faith, doctrine, practice, and salvation, with no second canonical revelation owed) is well-grounded. The strong form (sola scriptura, Scripture sufficient absent any subordinate tradition or church witness) is honestly complicated by Paul's positive paradosis (G3862) commands in 2 Thess 2:15, 1 Cor 11:2, 2 Thess 3:6, where apostolic tradition is transmitted dia logou or di' epistolēs and bound on the church. The 2 Tim 3:17 artios + exartizō pairing carries functional sufficiency for the equipped believer; it does not lexically rule on the Scripture-plus-Tradition question that divides Reformation from Roman and Eastern lineages. Verdict null on the strong Protestant-confessional form; the soft form holds with medium confidence.

Reasoning

The verdict is split. The soft form of the claim, that Scripture is enough to teach a believer everything needed for salvation and a godly life, with no second revelation owed, is well grounded by the text. Second Timothy 3:16-17 says all Scripture is breathed out by God and useful for teaching, for showing what is wrong, for putting things right, and for training in righteousness, so that the person of God may be complete, thoroughly equipped for every good work. The phrase thoroughly equipped is a strong word that means a craftsman whose toolkit has every tool needed for the job. Second Peter 1:3 says God has given us everything we need for life and godliness. Deuteronomy 4:2 says do not add to the word I command you, and do not subtract from it. Revelation 22:18-19 closes the canon with a similar warning. Jude 3 calls the faith once for all delivered to the saints, which means a finished deposit. The strongest counterargument comes from Scripture itself. In Second Thessalonians 2:15 Paul tells the church to stand firm and hold to the traditions taught, whether by his spoken word or by his letter. In First Corinthians 11:2 he commends keeping the traditions just as he delivered them. In Second Thessalonians 3:6 he commands withdrawing from any brother who does not walk according to the tradition received. So the same Bible that closes the canon also speaks of apostolic tradition being handed on. The verdict handles this tension by separating two readings. The soft reading, that Scripture is enough for salvation and godliness and contains a finished deposit, holds. The strong reading, that Scripture alone is sufficient without any role for apostolic tradition or living church witness, is not lexically settled by the text itself, because the text both names a finished deposit and commands holding apostolic tradition. The verdict is therefore null on the strong claim with medium confidence, while honestly affirming the soft claim that no second canonical revelation is owed and that Scripture is enough to make the believer complete for every good work.

Denominational landscape

The Roman Catholic teaching in the Second Vatican Council document *Dei Verbum* sections 9 and 10 says sacred Scripture and sacred Tradition flow from the same divine wellspring and form one sacred deposit, and that the Church does not draw her certainty about everything revealed from Scripture alone. The Eastern Orthodox position, expressed in the Orthodox Church in America catechism, says Holy Tradition is the life of the Holy Spirit in the Church and that Scripture lives within Tradition rather than over against it. Both deny the strong *sola scriptura* form. The Reformation lineages affirm the strong form with internal variation. The Lutheran Formula of Concord names the prophetic and apostolic Scriptures as the only rule and norm by which all doctrines and teachers must be judged. The Anglican Thirty Nine Articles, article six, titled *Of the Sufficiency of the Holy Scriptures for Salvation*, says Holy Scripture contains all things necessary to salvation, so whatever is not read in it nor may be proved by it is not to be required as an article of faith. The Methodist Articles of Religion, article five, repeats the same. The Reformed lineage in the Westminster Confession and the Second London Baptist Confession of 1689 grounds Scripture as the supreme judge. The Anabaptist Schleithem Confession grounds church order in Scripture. The Pentecostal Assemblies of God confess Scripture as the infallible authoritative rule of faith and conduct. The patristic picture is mixed. Basil of Caesarea in *On the Holy Spirit* defended unwritten apostolic traditions as having the same force as written ones. Irenaeus in *Against Heresies* appealed to apostolic succession alongside Scripture. Vincent of Lerins gave the rule of what has been believed everywhere, always, and by all. The denial of the strong form by Catholic and Orthodox traditions is not heterodox or cultic; it is a different reading of how apostolic deposit is preserved. By contrast, denial of any closed deposit, as in groups that claim continuing canonical revelation such as Mormonism with the Book of Mormon and continuing prophetic edicts, the Iglesia ni Cristo with Felix Manalo as final messenger, or the message movement of William Branham as added revelation, places those groups outside historic Christianity because they reject the closure of the canonical deposit that all major lineages affirm.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	No
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	Yes
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	Yes
Would publicly correct if otherwise	No

Notes

Soft form (Scripture sufficiently equips the believer for every good work, contains all things necessary for salvation, and admits no further canonical revelation) is well-supported by 2 Tim 3:16-17 *artios + exartizō*, 2 Pet 1:3 *panta ta pros zōēn kai eusebeian*, Deut 4:2 *do not add or subtract*, Rev 22:18-19 *textual integrity warning*, and Jude 3 *hapax paradotheisē*. Strong form (*sola scriptura*: Scripture alone is sufficient without any role for apostolic tradition or church witness as subordinate authority) is honestly complicated by Paul's positive *paradosis* commands in 2 Thess 2:15, 1 Cor 11:2, 2 Thess 3:6. Roman Catholic *Dei Verbum* and Eastern Orthodox Holy-Tradition readings deny the strong form: Scripture is sufficient within Tradition, not over against it. Lutheran, Anglican, Reformed, Methodist, Anabaptist, Pentecostal lineages

broadly affirm the strong form. The dispute is over the locus of apostolic deposit, not over whether God has finished revealing what is needful for salvation. Convictional question, not gospel-stake; both Trinitarian readings preserve the gospel. Not a cult marker. Honest Catholic and Orthodox believers denying sola scriptura are not cults. Public correction reserved for clear gospel-essence errors; this is an authority-structure question where charitable disagreement among Trinitarian Christians is appropriate. Children-teaching guarded because the framing of where the deposit lives shapes how every other doctrinal question is settled.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. sola-scriptura, prima-scriptura, scripture-and-tradition-co-source

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

Competing lens verdicts

sola-scriptura · **affirms**: Reads 2 Tim 3:16-17 artios plus exartizō, 2 Pet 1:3 panta ta pros zōēn kai eusebeian, Deut 4:2, Rev 22:18-19, Jude 3 hapax paradotheisē as establishing Scripture as functionally sufficient and as a closed deposit not requiring co-equal Tradition; reads Paul's positive paradosis commands as referring to apostolic-era oral transmission of content substantively preserved in the canon and now ceased with the apostles; this is the Reformation reading

prima-scriptura · **complicates**: Holds Scripture as supreme and materially sufficient for salvation while recognizing tradition, ecumenical council, and church witness as subordinate authorities that aid right interpretation; this lens reads 2 Tim 3:17 sufficiency as material sufficiency (Scripture contains all needed truth) while granting formal authority to tradition and church for unfolding what is materially present; the Wesleyan quadrilateral, Anglican three-stranded cord, and modern evangelical mainstream land here in different proportions

scripture-and-tradition-co-source · **denies**: Reads 2 Thess 2:15 plus 1 Cor 11:2 plus 2 Thess 3:6 as establishing apostolic Tradition as a co-source flowing from the same divine wellspring as Scripture; Scripture is sufficient within Tradition, not above or apart from it; this is the Dei Verbum and Eastern Orthodox reading; denies the strong sufficiency form while affirming that no further canonical revelation is owed

The 2 Tim 3:17 artios plus exartizō pairing carries strong functional-sufficiency language: the believer is complete and thoroughly equipped for every good work through Scripture. This grounds the soft form. The strong form (sola scriptura excluding any role for tradition) is not lexically forced by the artios plus exartizō construction; it is a downstream inference about whether the deposit lives in Scripture alone or in Scripture within Tradition. The paradosis word group is morally context-determined: Mark 7 condemns paradosis that nullifies God's command, while 2 Thess 2:15 commands holding apostolic paradosis. Progressive revelation is a factor: the Mosaic torah was complete for its dispensation (Ps 19:7 temimah), the apostolic deposit completes the canon (Jude 3 hapax paradotheisē). Analogia scripturae is essential because Scripture both closes the canon and commands holding apostolic tradition; these cannot be played against each other.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

2Tim.3.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. πᾶσα γραφή θεόπνευστος καὶ ὠφέλιμος (pasa graphē theopneustos kai ōphelimos) G3956 + G1124 + G2315 + G5624

Force. Every (or all) Scripture is God-breathed and profitable for teaching (didaskalia), reproof (elegmos), correction (epanorthōsis), and training (paideia) in righteousness (dikaiosynē); the four-fold profitability catalogue covers doctrinal formation and ethical formation comprehensively.

2Tim.3.17 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key term. ἄρτιος (artios) G739 hapax + ἐξηρτισμένος (exērtismenos) G1822 perfect passive participle of exartizō

Force. Purpose clause hina: that the anthrōpos tou theou may be artios (complete, fitted, ready) and exartizō (thoroughly furnished, fully equipped) for every good work; the artios plus exartizō pairing is functional-sufficiency language meaning the believer's toolkit is complete for the task of godliness.

2Pet.1.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. πάντα τὰ πρὸς ζωὴν καὶ εὐσέβειαν (panta ta pros zōēn kai eusebeian) G3956 + G2222 + G2150; δέδωρημένης (dedōrēmenēs) G1433 perfect middle of dōreomai

Force. His divine power (theia dynamis) has granted (dōreomai, perfect aspect, completed action with abiding result) to us all things (panta) pertaining to life (zōē) and godliness (eusebeia) through the epignōsis of the One who called us; functional-sufficiency claim on the divine side of provision for godliness.

Deut.4.2 · for · genre: law

Key term. לֹא תוֹסֵף וְלֹא תִקַּח (lo tosifu al-ha-davar) H3254 Hiphil; וְלֹא תִגַּד (ve-lo tigra'u) H1639 Qal

Force. Do not add (yasaph Hiphil, causative addition) to the word I command you, nor take away (gara Qal) from it, that you may keep the commandments of YHWH your God; canonical-closure principle applied to the Mosaic torah; supports Scripture as the bounded authoritative deposit not to be supplemented or diminished.

Rev.22.18 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key term. ἐάν τις ἐπιθή (ean tis epithē) G2007 aorist subjunctive of epitithēmi

Force. If anyone adds (epitithēmi, place upon) to the words of the prophecy of this scroll, God will add (epitithēmi future indicative) to him the plagues written in this scroll; canonical-closure warning on the prophetic book; scope is the words of this scroll but the principle extends the Deut 4:2 pattern.

Rev.22.19 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key term. ἐάν τις ἀφέλῃ (ean tis aphelē) G851 aorist subjunctive of aphaireō

Force. If anyone takes away (aphaireō, remove) from the words of the book of this prophecy, God will take away (aphaireō future indicative) his share of the tree of life and the holy city; symmetric to v18 closing the canonical text with prohibition on both addition and subtraction.

Jude.1.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἅπαξ παραδοθείση (hapax paradotheisē) G530 + G3860 aorist passive participle of paradidōmi

Force. The faith was once for all (hapax, one time only with no repetition) delivered (paradotheisē) to the saints; hapax plus aorist passive implies a closed deposit handed over completely; supports the no-further-revelation clause of the sufficiency claim directly.

Ps.19.7 · for · genre: psalm

Key term. תּוֹרַת יְהוָה תְּמִימָה (torat YHWH temimah) H8451 + H8549

Force. The torah of YHWH is temimah (perfect, complete, whole, without lack) reviving the soul (meshivat nephesh); the testimony of YHWH is ne'emanah (faithful, sure) making wise the simple; canonical assertion that the written torah is functionally complete for the work of restoring the inner person.

Ps.119.105 · for · genre: psalm · figures: metaphor

Key term. נֶר לְרַגְלִי יְהוָה (ner le-ragli devarekha) H5216 + H1697

Force. Your word is a lamp (ner) to my feet and a light (or) to my path; functional-guidance metaphor for the written word as sufficient guide for the walking life of the believer; complements the 2 Tim 3:16-17 equipping claim.

2Thess.2.15 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. κρατεῖτε τὰς παραδόσεις (krateite tas paradoseis) G2902 + G3862; διὰ λόγου εἴτε δι' ἐπιστολῆς ἡμῶν (dia logou eite di' epistolēs hēmōn) G3056 + G1992

Force. Paul commands the Thessalonians to stand firm and hold fast (krateō, present imperative, active grasp) to the paradoseis they were taught, whether through oral word or through our letter; the apostolic tradition is transmitted through two channels both bearing the apostolic stamp; complicates strong-form sola scriptura that excludes any role for apostolic tradition.

1Cor.11.2 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. παραδόσεις καθὼς παρέδωκα (paradoseis kathōs paredōka) G3862 + G3860

Force. Paul commends the Corinthians for holding the paradoseis just as he delivered (paradidōmi, aorist) them; the apostolic deposit is being actively transmitted in a way that warrants commendation; positive paradosis valence; complicates strong-form sola scriptura.

2Thess.3.6 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. παράδοσιν ἣν παρελάβετε (paradosin hēn parelabete) G3862 + G3880

Force. Paul commands withdrawal from any brother walking ataktōs (disorderly) and not according to the paradosis received from us; the apostolic paradosis carries binding ethical force backed by apostolic discipline; complicates strong-form claim.

Concordance lemmas traversed

G1124, G2315, G5624, G739, G1822, G3956, G2222, G2150, G1433, G3862, G3860, G3880, G2902, G2007, G851, G530, H3254, H1639, H8451, H8549, H1697

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

anglican · 39 Articles, Article VI Of the Sufficiency of the Holy Scriptures for Salvation (1571) · affirms · verified

“Holy Scripture containeth all things necessary to salvation: so that whatsoever is not read therein, nor may be proved thereby, is not to be required of any man, that it should be believed as an article of the Faith”

methodist · Articles of Religion (UMC), Article V (Wesley's 1784 abridgement of the 39 Articles) · affirms · verified

“The Holy Scriptures contain all things necessary to salvation; so that whatsoever is not read therein, nor may be proved thereby, is not to be required of any man that it should be believed as an article of faith”

lutheran · Formula of Concord, Epitome, Of the Comprehensive Summary, Rule and Norm (1577) · affirms · verified

“the prophetic and apostolic writings of the Old and New Testaments alone is the only rule and norm according to which all doctrines and all teachers alike must be appraised and judged”

reformed · Westminster Confession 1.6 (1646) · affirms · verified

“The whole counsel of God concerning all things necessary for His own glory, man's salvation, faith, and life, is either expressly set down in Scripture, or by good and necessary consequence may be deduced from Scripture”

reformed · Second London Baptist Confession 1.6 (1689) · affirms · verified

“The whole counsel of God concerning all things necessary for his own glory, man's salvation, faith and life, is either expressly set down or necessarily contained in the Holy Scripture”

anabaptist · Schleithem Confession (1527), preamble · affirms · verified

“we are minded with all subjection, practically eager, to obey the Word and will of God, the Father, Son and Holy Ghost”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths, Article 1 The Scriptures Inspired · affirms · verified

“The Scriptures, both the Old and New Testaments, are verbally inspired of God and are the revelation of God to man, the infallible, authoritative rule of faith and conduct”

catholic_magisterial · Dei Verbum 9 (Second Vatican Council, 1965) · denies · verified

“Sacred Tradition and Sacred Scripture, then, are bound closely together, and communicate one with the other...flowing out from the same divine well-spring, come together in some fashion to form one thing”

catholic_magisterial · Dei Verbum 9 (Second Vatican Council, 1965) · denies · verified

“Consequently it is not from Sacred Scripture alone that the Church draws her certainty about everything which has been revealed”

catholic_magisterial · Dei Verbum 10 (Second Vatican Council, 1965) · denies · verified

“Sacred Tradition, Sacred Scripture, and the teaching authority of the Church...are so connected and associated that one of them cannot stand without the others”

eastern_orthodox · OCA Orthodox Faith, Sources of Christian Doctrine, Holy Tradition · denies · verified

“Holy Tradition is the very life of the Church itself as it is inspired and guided by the Holy Spirit. Among the elements...the Bible holds the first place”

eastern_orthodox · OCA Orthodox Faith, Sources of Christian Doctrine, Holy Tradition · denies · verified

“Holy Tradition is not at all limited to what is written; it is...the total life and experience of the entire Church transferred from place to place and from generation to generation”

patristic · Basil of Caesarea, On the Holy Spirit 27.66 (circa 375) · complicates · verified

“Of the beliefs and practices...some we possess derived from written teaching; others we have received delivered to us in a mystery by the tradition of the apostles; and both...have the same force”

patristic · Vincent of Lerins, Commonitorium 2.6 (434) · complicates · verified

“in the Catholic Church itself, all possible care must be taken, that we hold that faith which has been believed everywhere, always, by all”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/2_timothy/3-16.htm

“pasa graphē theopneustos kai ōphelimos pros didaskalian pros elegmon pros epanorthōsin pros paideian tēn en dikaiosynē (every scripture God-breathed and profitable for teaching, reproof, correction, training in righteousness)”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/greek/739.htm>

“artios G739 hapax NT, complete, fitted, ready to function in the immediate present; operational readiness rather than abstract perfection; appears only in 2 Tim 3:17”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/greek/1822.htm>

“exartizō G1822 to equip fully, furnish thoroughly; prefix ek intensifies; in 2 Tim 3:17 perfect passive: the believer stands equipped for every good work”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/2_peter/1-3.htm

“tēs theias dynamēōs autou ta pros zōēn kai eusebeian dedōrēmenēs (his divine power has granted all things pertaining to life and godliness)”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/deuteronomy/4-2.htm>

“lo tosifu al ha-davar asher anokhi metsavveh etkhem ve-lo tigre'u mimmennu (do not add to the word I command you and do not subtract from it)”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/revelation/22-18.htm>

“ean tis epithē ep' auta epithēsei ho theos ep' auton tas plēgas tas gegrammenas en tō bibliō toutō (if anyone adds, God will add the plagues written)”

complicates · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/2_thessalonians/2-15.htm

“stēkete kai krateite tas paradoseis has edidachthēte eite dia logou eite di epistolēs hēmōn (stand and hold the traditions taught, by word or by our letter)”

nuance · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/greek/3862.htm>

“paradosis G3862 a handing down or over, a tradition; 13 NT uses; positive apostolic and negative human valences in same word; Mark 7 condemns human tradition, 2 Thess 2:15 commands apostolic tradition”

opposes · category: magisterial ·

https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_const_19651118_dei-verbum_en.html

“Consequently it is not from Sacred Scripture alone that the Church draws her certainty about everything which has been revealed (Dei Verbum 9)”

opposes · category: tradition_primary ·

<https://www.oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/doctrine/sources-of-christian-doctrine/tradition>

“Tradition is the very life of the Church itself as it is inspired and guided by the Holy Spirit; Bible holds the first place among elements of Holy Tradition”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/epitome/rule-and-norm/>

“the prophetic and apostolic Scriptures of the Old and of the New Testament alone serve as the sole rule and standard according to which all dogmas together with all teachers should be estimated and judged”

supports · category: tradition_primary · https://anglicansonline.org/basics/thirty-nine_articles.html

“Article VI: Holy Scripture containeth all things necessary to salvation: so that whatsoever is not read therein, nor may be proved thereby, is not to be required of any man”

Flags

- lexically-contested-strong-form
- framework-divergence

- confession-tradition-divergence
- apparatus-vs-counter-witness-conflict